

Remote control devices using your mobile

Belkin has launched a series of home automation products called WeMo that let you control your home electronics devices from anywhere using a mobile app. They are in line with the 'connected home' concept—a key aspect of the IoT. The WeMo Switch, a part of this series, is an intelligent power socket that works with an iOS application. It makes use of your home's Wi-Fi network to provide wireless control of TVs, lamps, stereos and more. Using mobile Internet, you can also control the devices from anywhere. Simply download the free WeMo app, plug the switch into an outlet in your home and plug any device into the switch. You can turn the device on or off, or even set schedules for its operation. For example, you can program the coffee maker to switch on and brew for 10 minutes just before you arrive home, so you get fresh coffee when you get in! There is also a motion-sensor-based product called WeMo Motion that lets you program devices to work based on the presence or movement of people.

Inside: WeMo Switch looks like any normal power switch (although it is definitely bigger), and can also be controlled physically like normal switches. It is Wi-Fi capable—and can be remotely controlled through an app that runs on iOS 4.3 or higher version. Belkin is apparently also addressing customer requests for an Android version of the app. Apart from simple remote on/off controls, WeMo can also be scheduled to switch on or off at specific times. It can be programmed to react to situations using a service called IFTTT, which is actually the most innovative aspect of WeMo. IFTTT stands for 'if-this-then-that.' You can set up WeMo equipment to react to changes. For example, you can set it up to switch on when somebody comes in. Better still, it is Web-enabled, so you can link the functioning of devices to, say, weather reports, or you can turn it on or off using Twitter or other social media messages. WeMo can also talk back—it can post information or trigger events on Facebook, Twitter, etc, send you an SMS or update Google Calendar!



Wireless sensor to take good care of your plants

Many of us love gardening but are not smart enough to take good care of plants. Well, caring for plants is tough—you need to understand when they need water, shade or even nutrients. Imagine having an electronic advisor that knows all this, monitors your plants personally and advises you on what to do, through a mobile application. Well, that is precisely what the Parrot Flower Power solution does, using sensors and a mobile app. It is a small device from the makers of the Parrot AR Drone, which plugs into the soil in your garden and helps take care of plants in the vicinity. Flower Power will be launched this year.

Inside: The Parrot Flower Power device includes sensors that measure sunlight, soil moisture, temperature and fertiliser content in soil. It is Bluetooth Smart capable, and keeps sending information to a dedicated iOS application, which monitors and analyses the sensor data. The app includes a comprehensive database with information about 6000+ species of plants. Once you plug your Parrot Flower Power device into the soil, you need to choose the type of plants in the garden. If you do not know this, you can search the database based on leaf type, colour and a number of other options. Apparently, you can associate the device with any number of species. Once this simple setup is over, you are ready to go. The device keeps sending information to your app every 15 minutes. The app then puts two-and-two together and decides whether the plants have sufficient light, water and fertiliser to grow well. It then pushes notifications to your phone about the status of the plants and action to be taken. The information may also be plotted in the form of a graph or analysed in other ways for long-term benefits.

